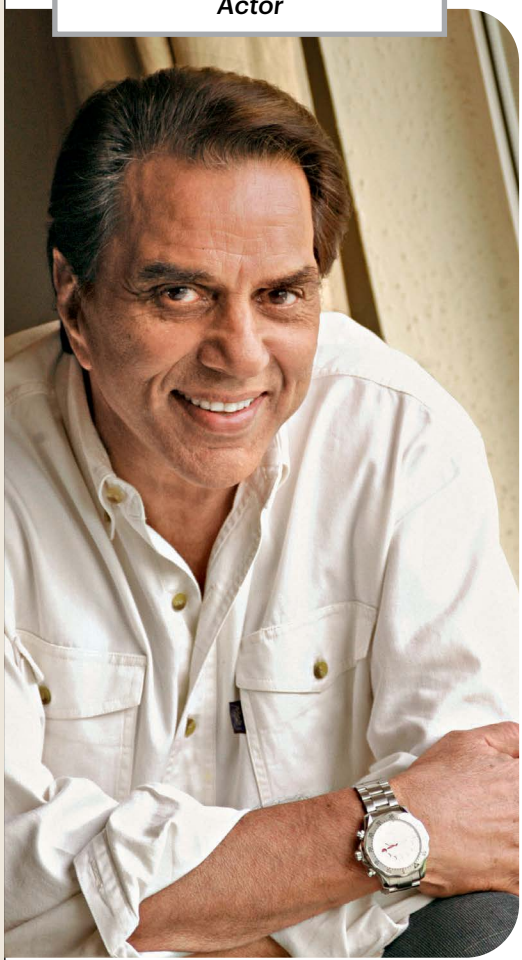
DHARMENDRA | b. 1935 |

Actor



BANDEEP SINGH

Seething anger, impish fun, romance, machismo, just being handsome—all of it came naturally to Dharmendra. Unlike those who leaned towards method acting, he was a naturalistic performer who wore his heart on his sleeves. A mere listing of his standout hits—even as varied as *Phool Aur Patthar* (1966), *Sholay* (1975), *Chupke Chupke* (1975) or *Dharam Veer* (1977)—wouldn't capture what he achieved in a career that spanned six decades. Born in a village near Ludhiana, what he attained was an unparalleled iconicity as the ultimate male hero figure in popular film. Gossip didn't evade him, but the *joie de vivre* and authenticity with which he rode through it kept the original 'He-Man' beloved of audiences as well as peers.

GOVARDHAN ASRANI | b. 1941 |

Actor-comedian



PTI

In the 1970s and '80s, if audiences went to the movies seeking laughter, Asrani was often the answer. Trained at the FTII, he commanded the screen with precise comic timing, becoming a familiar presence as Rajesh Khanna's loyal friend across numerous films. He perfected the art of the supporting role, making brief appearances feel indispensable. Some became indelible—most famously his Hitler-inflected jailor in *Sholay*. Asrani's ambitions as a leading man found fuller expression in Gujarati cinema, which he consistently championed.

SHIBU SOREN | b. 1944 |

Former Jharkhand CM



SOMNATH SEN

They called him 'Dishom Guru'—translate that Santhali phrase into something like Pathfinder of the Nation, and you know what he meant to the Adivasis. 'Nation' here means the 'people', a group kept disenfranchised by colonial policy that bled seamlessly into modern India. As Jharkhand Mukti Morcha founder, Soren turned their demand for rights and dignity into a state. Even if an imperfect wielder of formal power in later years, he had performed his role in history by then.